THE REFINERY
A BioNanomics program
Electric Works, Fort Wayne, Ind.

Monster Match 2026

Press kit

A FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event, college and career fair and costume contest
Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026, matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.
Wayne High School, 9100 Winchester Road, Fort Wayne, IN 46819
Free and open to the public

Co-hosted by The REFINERY, Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, Region 8 Education Service Center and NEI TechFest

Coverage before Oct. 31 is welcome. Teams are preparing their robots now, and we will arrange shop visits and interviews ahead of the event on request.

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Press portal (photos, video, logos, release)
https://refineryrobotics.org/press/

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A BioNanomics program
Electric Works, Fort Wayne, Ind.

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
Oct. 5, 2026

High school robots in Halloween costumes compete at Wayne High School Oct. 31 as Monster Match pairs a FIRST Robotics Competition with a college and career fair

Co-hosted by The REFINERY, Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, Region 8 Education Service Center and NEI TechFest. Free and open to the public; matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.

FORT WAYNE, Ind. – On Saturday, Oct. 31, high school robotics teams bring the robots they designed and built this year to Wayne High School for Monster Match, a Halloween-themed FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event. Seventeen teams are registered and the field stays open until it reaches 32.

The day combines a robotics competition, a college and career fair and a costume contest with categories for individuals, teams and robots. To be eligible in the robot category, a robot has to play its matches in costume. Admission is free. Matches run from 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.

Every January, FIRST Robotics Competition releases a new game to more than 3,700 high school teams worldwide at the same moment, and teams have about two months to design and build a machine to play it before competitions begin in March. This year's game, REBUILT, asked robots to collect foam balls, shoot them into a goal on a 54-foot field and climb a tower in the final seconds of each match.

The robots can weigh up to 115 pounds. Students do the work: they design in CAD, machine the metal parts, wire the electronics, write the code and drive in matches where alliances of three robots play against three.

Teams also run like small companies, raising their own money, recruiting sponsors and managing their own budgets. Participants are eligible for more than $80 million in college scholarships.

Offseason events like Monster Match give teams one more chance to compete with this year's robots and a chance to train newer members before the next game is released on Jan. 9. Because it falls on Halloween, Monster Match adds costume contests, trick-or-treating and a robot photo booth.

In the same building, colleges, employers and trade and technical schools host a college and career fair, putting students in front of the regional employers who need the skills they use to build a robot. Families can trick-or-treat through the exhibitor booths and watch matches throughout the day.

Monster Match is co-hosted by The REFINERY; Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, a student organization at Purdue University Fort Wayne; Region 8 Education Service Center, the cooperative of public, private and parochial schools serving 15 Northeast Indiana counties; and NEI TechFest, the Northeast Indiana Tech Coalition's annual event connecting high school students with the region's technology employers. Sponsors include Daniels Associates, Inc.; Resultant; the City of Fort Wayne; Indiana Tech; and Huntington University.

About The REFINERY

The REFINERY is Northeast Indiana's first robotics-only facility, a nonprofit makerspace at Electric Works operated by BioNanomics, a nonprofit. It gives FIRST Robotics Competition and FIRST Tech Challenge teams across a 12-county region the shop space, fabrication equipment, training and mentorship that many of them could not afford on their own. refineryrobotics.org

WHAT	Monster Match, a FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event, college and career fair and costume contest
WHEN	Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026, matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.
WHERE	Wayne High School, 9100 Winchester Road, Fort Wayne, IN 46819
ADMISSION	Free and open to the public
TEAM REGISTRATION	Free, teamconvene.org/event/the-refinery/monster-match
FOR MEDIA	Students and mentors are available for interviews before the event, and media are welcome at Wayne High School throughout the day on Oct. 31. Photos, video and logos: https://refineryrobotics.org/press/. Official FIRST photography: firstinspires.org/about/press-room/first-photos (credit: Photo courtesy FIRST).

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Media contact: Cameron Elder, Creative Director, The REFINERY
celder@bionanomics.com
260-450-9038

Fact sheet

Event	Monster Match: FIRST Robotics Competition offseason event, college and career fair and costume contest
Date and hours	Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026. Matches 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m.
Venue	Wayne High School, 9100 Winchester Road, Fort Wayne, IN 46819
Admission	Free and open to the public
Co-hosts	The REFINERY (a BioNanomics program), Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne, Region 8 Education Service Center, NEI TechFest (Northeast Indiana Tech Coalition)
Sponsors	Daniels Associates, Inc.; Resultant; the City of Fort Wayne; Indiana Tech; and Huntington University
Teams	17 registered as of Oct. 5. The field caps at 32. Registration is free.
Game	REBUILT, the 2026 FIRST Robotics Competition game. Robots collect foam balls, score them in a central goal on a 27 by 54 ft field and climb a tower in the final seconds. Two alliances of three robots per match.
Robots	Up to 115 lb. Designed, machined, wired, programmed and driven by high school students, built in about two months after the January game release.
Costume contest	Individual, team and robot categories. A robot must compete in costume to be eligible.
Also on site	College and career fair with colleges, employers and trade and technical schools. Trick-or-treating through the exhibitor booths. Robot photo booth.
Prize	If registration reaches 24 teams, each team on the winning alliance receives a Bambu Lab X2D Combo 3D printer, purchased by The REFINERY.
Load-in	Friday, Oct. 30. Media welcome.
Event page	teamconvene.org/event/the-refinery/monster-match
Web and social	refineryrobotics.org. @refineryrobotics on Instagram and YouTube.
Media contact	Cameron Elder, celder@bionanomics.com, 260-450-9038

Story ideas

Robots in costume

The costume contest has a robot category, and a robot has to play its matches in costume to qualify. Students and whole teams dress up as well.

Keeping a robot alive for ten months

These robots were built in January and February and have been running ever since: two, three or four competitions for most teams, plus outreach events and public displays through the summer. Getting one through a full day of matches at the end of October means repairing, replacing and maintaining a machine that was never meant to last this long. Teams are doing that work right now.

Two brand-new teams built for this event

Team 1501 T.H.R.U.S.T. of Huntington County has created a second team to compete at Monster Match. At Homestead High School, the rookie members of 4982 Olympus Robotics built their own robot this fall and will compete with it on their own, without the veterans, for the first time.

A day in the pits

Students drive every match. Between matches the robot goes back to the pit, where students diagnose, repair and rebuild under the clock before the next match is called. A reporter can spend the day with one team and follow one robot from its first match to its last.

Fort Wayne's first offseason event at this scale

Fort Wayne has hosted an offseason event before, but not one this size, and this is the first offseason event The REFINERY has hosted. The REFINERY is a nonprofit shop at Electric Works that supports 15 FIRST teams and about 200 students across 12 counties.

What comes next

The 2027 game, BIOCORE, is released Jan. 9, 2027. The FIRST Indiana Robotics district event in Fort Wayne is April 1 to 3, 2027 at Homestead High School.

Spokespeople

Interviews are arranged through Cameron Elder, celder@bionanomics.com, 260-450-9038. Student interviews with any competing team can be arranged through the team's coach.

Mady Stricker, Operations Director, The REFINERY. Handles Monster Match team registration and event operations.

Doug Horner, Founder and CEO, BioNanomics; Founder, The REFINERY. Co-founder and CEO of Medical Informatics Engineering, Fort Wayne. Recipient of the 2025 FIRST Indiana Robotics President's Award.

Connor Rey, Operations, The REFINERY.

Cameron Elder, Creative Director, The REFINERY and BioNanomics. Media contact for the event.

The co-hosts

The REFINERY is Northeast Indiana's first robotics-only facility, a nonprofit makerspace at Electric Works in Fort Wayne operated by BioNanomics. It gives FIRST Robotics Competition and FIRST Tech Challenge teams across a 12-county region shop space, fabrication equipment, training and mentorship: 15 teams, about 200 students, five new teams launched, $75,000 moved to teams. refineryrobotics.org

BioNanomics is a nonprofit biomakerspace at Electric Works, 1690 Broadway, Fort Wayne. It operates The REFINERY alongside a wet lab and an imaging lab, including a scanning electron microscope, open to the community at no charge. bionanomics.com

Purdue FIRST Programs Fort Wayne is a student organization at Purdue University Fort Wayne that supports FIRST robotics programs in the region.

NEI TechFest is the Northeast Indiana Tech Coalition's annual event connecting high school students with the region's technology employers through competitions and exhibits.

Region 8 Education Service Center is a voluntary cooperative of public, private and parochial schools serving 15 Northeast Indiana counties, based at The Summit in Fort Wayne. r8esc.k12.in.us

Wayne High School is a Fort Wayne Community Schools public high school of about 1,400 students, opened in 1971. Wayne's FRC team is 10411 G-Code Generals.

About FIRST

FIRST (For Inspiration and Recognition of Science and Technology) is a nonprofit that runs team-based youth robotics programs from kindergarten through 12th grade. FIRST Robotics Competition, for grades 9 to 12, fielded 3,724 teams in 2026. Indiana competes as a district, FIRST Indiana Robotics, with 69 FRC teams. Participants are eligible for more than $80 million in college scholarships from about 200 providers.

A match is played by two alliances of three robots each, red against blue, on a 27 by 54 ft field. The first 20 seconds are autonomous; student drivers then take over for 2 minutes 20

seconds. Robots are built from a kit of parts plus custom-machined and 3D-printed components and can weigh up to 115 pounds.

REBUILT, the 2026 game

Robots collect foam balls called Fuel and shoot them into a central goal called the Hub. In the final seconds, robots climb a multi-level Tower for bonus points. The robots at Monster Match are the machines teams built for REBUILT in January and February 2026; after the official season ends in April, teams keep their robots and compete at volunteer-run offseason events like this one. Monster Match is played on an AndyMark field.

Media advisory: Saturday, Oct. 31

Where and when

Wayne High School, 9100 Winchester Road, Fort Wayne, IN 46819. Matches run 8:15 a.m. to 6 p.m. Media are welcome throughout the day. Team load-in is Friday, Oct. 30, and media are welcome then as well.

On arrival

Call or text Cameron Elder at 260-450-9038 and someone from The REFINERY will meet you. Walk-ups are welcome; no credential is required.

Interviews

Mady Stricker, Doug Horner and Connor Rey of The REFINERY are available by arrangement, before the event and on the day. Student interviews with any competing team can be arranged through the team's coach.

Field and pits

Safety glasses are required in the pit area and at the field. Bring your own if you can; we will have pairs available if you don't. No one may step onto the field during a match or a field reset, but media will have access right up to the sideline.

Before the event

Teams are working on their robots now, and we would like to help you cover the lead-up as much as the day itself. Contact Cameron Elder at celder@bionanomics.com or 260-450-9038 and we will set you up with a team in its shop, a student, a mentor or any of the spokespeople above ahead of Oct. 31.

Live shots and crews

Contact Cameron Elder in advance to arrange a live hit or a specific interview on the day.

Contact on site

Cameron Elder, 260-450-9038.

Photos, video and logos

Press portal (photos, video, logos, release): https://refineryrobotics.org/press/

The press portal holds photos, video, logos and this release, hosted on refineryrobotics.org so it is reachable from networks that block file-sharing sites. Material produced by The REFINERY and BioNanomics may be used for editorial coverage of Monster Match, The REFINERY, BioNanomics and FIRST robotics in Northeast Indiana. Not for advertising, stock or resale.

Photos	Photos from The REFINERY and BioNanomics, including the Aug. 9, 2026 Science Central career fair. JPEG. Credit: Photo courtesy The REFINERY / BioNanomics.
Video	The REFINERY's Robot in 3 Days 2026 cut. More video is on The REFINERY's YouTube channel, youtube.com/@refineryrobotics. Credit: Video courtesy The REFINERY / BioNanomics. Contact us before using more than a short clip.
Logos	The REFINERY logo (SVG, full color and reversed). Monster Match and BioNanomics marks on request. Use as provided. No credit required.
Press release	Current release, on the press portal.
After Oct. 31	Photos and video from the event available on request.

From FIRST

Official FIRST photography of 2026 REBUILT match play, pits and drive teams is available for journalistic use from FIRST at firstinspires.org/about/press-room/first-photos. Credit: Photo courtesy FIRST. Photos of Indiana teams, including Fort Wayne teams, are in FIRST Indiana Robotics' public Flickr albums at flickr.com/photos/indianafirst/albums (2026 District Mishawaka, 2026 District Columbus, 2026 FIN State Championship, 2025 Boiler Bot Battle). Credit: Photo courtesy FIRST Indiana Robotics. FIRST's REBUILT game animation and 2026 season video are at youtube.com/user/FIRSTWorldTube.

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